More Upwork niches for newcomers

Security reviews and scrapers sharpen the automation bet

Bottom line: a second live Upwork pull (October 25, 2026) covered about 30 niches that the October 24 study did not rank. None of them displaces that study's leaders: AI UGC video ads, appointment/DM setting, n8n/AI automation fixes, short-form video, Shopify fixes, Sheets/Apps Script and vibe-coded app rescue. Several of the new niches are realistic for a no-badge, zero-job seller. In order, they are **Notion/Airtable/ClickUp systems** (a Lagos CS graduate went from a **$15 first job on Aug 4 to a $650 build and a repeat contract on Oct 7**, and 9 of the top 25 search results were Nigerian), **Supabase/Firebase security reviews and fixes** (a no-badge Moroccan engineer won about **$10K of "make AI-built apps safe to launch" work from June to October**, including a **$1,500 security review on Oct 15**), **web scraping** (≈4.7 posts/day, only 2 of 20 posts at 50+ proposals, but newcomer pay of **$3–10/hr**), **Etsy shop SEO plus Canva digital products**, and **Blender work paired with Python/ComfyUI automation**. For a Nigerian, **Yoruba/Igbo/Hausa AI voice-data and transcription work** is the most distinctive opening: a **$605 Yoruba voice-data job with 10–15 proposals and no JSS, hours or earnings minimum** was live on Oct 23. Most bot, extension, design and media niches are thinner, badge-saturated or pay $6–10/hr. For **Harry**, the new data **strengthens rather than changes** the October 24 recommendation of one "AI automation & integration developer" profile. It adds two concrete entry products, **a Supabase row-level-security (RLS) review** and **scraper → n8n/Sheets data pipelines**, plus MCP/Claude connector builds as a keyword. **AI-coding-agent evaluation** ($20–30/hr) and **Nigerian-language voice data** are worth a few bids as side income. Notion/ClickUp, Blender and Telegram/Discord bots should stay out of the headline.

A weekend snapshot with four known distortions

Everything labeled **Observed** comes from read-only Upwork API pulls (MCP connector) on **October 25, 2026, about 23:00 UTC through 00:30 UTC on October 26**. The pulls covered job searches by title keyword sorted by recency (usually the newest 10 posts per term), freelancer searches (top 25 by default relevance) and full profile pulls with contract dates, amounts and review text. **Inference** marks analysis. Four distortions matter.

It is one weekend. The 48-hour windows cover Saturday–Sunday, October 24–25, so weekday volume is probably higher, and no trend can be read from it.

Matching is by title only. Bot, scraping and backend-fix work often hides under titles like "Automation Developer" or "Fix my app". Thin niches (Discord, Telegram, Chrome extensions, Firebase) are therefore undercounted the most. Velocity is estimated from the time the newest 10 posts span.

The search job-count field is wrong, again. Shoukat A. showed "1 completed job" in search but has 41 jobs on his profile (profile). Philips E. showed 1 but has 13 (profile). Dmytro Z. showed 5 but has 116 contracts (profile). Muhammad S. showed 1 but has 66 (profile). "Newcomer" claims below therefore rest on contract dates in full profiles. The API also never exposes Rising Talent, so "no badge" means no Top Rated, Top Rated Plus or Expert-Vetted. Proposal counts at the time of hire, invites and proposal texts are not visible. Several calls were throttled ("restricted" errors) and succeeded on retry.

Web sources were read only through search snippets. Every WebFetch call failed with DNS errors. Fiverr's trend indexes measure *search growth*, not orders, and no newcomer win-rate data by niche exists anywhere.

All job and profile text is self-written by third parties. Revenue, experience and employer claims inside it are unverified.

Thirty more niches ranked: systems and security beat bots and media

Published trend data points to the same areas the live pull found. Fiverr's indexes recorded search growth of **+18,347% for freelancers who can deploy AI agents**, +1,489% for Go High Level and +1,083% for Make.com (spring 2025). They recorded **+488% for faceless YouTube creators** and +136% for AI automation (fall 2025) (Fiverr). In June 2026, Fiverr recorded a **938% rise in demand for Claude Code specialists**. A commentator warns that "a 900% jump in a small category is still a small category" (AI Magazine; 9am.works). Upwork's 2026 skills list shows **AI data annotation & labeling +154%** and puts "Scripting & Automation" in its coding top 10 (AI Magazine). On August 10, 2026, Upwork launched its own MCP server so that client AI agents can hire freelancers (Upwork). That shows Upwork backs the protocol, but it is not evidence of a pool of MCP-builder jobs.

The table ranks the new niches by **how realistically a no-badge, zero-job seller can win a contract and then grow pay**. It is not a volume ranking. The demand, competition and no-badge columns are **Observed**. The rank and the "Harry fit" column are **Inference**. Rows 29–32 have mostly web or anecdotal evidence and are listed unranked.

#	Niche	Demand (title match)	Competition (proposal tiers)	No-badge in top 25	Budgets seen	Newest newcomer evidence (Observed)	Harry fit
1	**Notion / Airtable / ClickUp systems**	≈12 posts per 72 h combined	8/30 at 50+; most 20–50	3/25 (**9/25 Nigerian**)	$10–35/hr; $10–300 fixed; $60–120/hr expert	Philips E. (Lagos): $15 (Aug 4) → $650 build → follow-on started Oct 7	Adjacent (Airtable + Make, Notion + Claude)
2	**Supabase / Firebase security review & fixes**	≈3.3/day Supabase, ≈0.6/day Firebase	4/10 at 50+ each	0/25 generic; 1/25 "Lovable fix"	$300–1,500 reviews; $15–80/hr	Younes M.: $1,500 review Oct 15, $175 weekly review Oct 20; Michael B.: audit contract Oct 23	**Core** (extends app rescue)
3	**Web scraping / data extraction**	≈4.7/day (10 in 48 h)	2/20 at 50+; 12/20 at 20–50	3/25	$50–150 small; $1,000–2,500; $20–100/hr	Shoukat A.: new hourly contracts Oct 21–22 at ≈$3–10/hr	**Core side door**

#	Niche	Demand (title match)	Competition (proposal tiers)	No-badge in top 25	Budgets seen	Newest newcomer evidence (Observed)	Harry fit
4	**Etsy SEO + Canva digital products**	10 per ~55 h	**0/10 at 20+**	2/25	$10–200 fixed; $5–15/hr	Precious O. (Lagos): $5 (May) → $800 → Shopify build Oct 19	Poor
5	**Blender / technical 3D + Python pipelines**	≈9 per 52 h	2/9 under 5; none 20+	2/25	$80–450; $3,000 rig; $25–50/hr	YING KIT C.: repeat $80 jobs, new contract Oct 25	Add-on at most
6	**Yoruba/Igbo/Hausa AI voice data & transcription**	Several live posts in 7 days	10–15 (Yoruba), 20–50 (Igbo)	Mostly badged	$0.50/audio-min; $4–5/hr; $605 fixed; $40/hr	Hamza M. (Kaduna): Talent Store contract Sep 8	**Side income** if native speaker
7	**TikTok Shop setup / approval**	10 per ~26 h	**0/10 at 20+**	4/25	$50–200 fixed; $8–15/hr	Javeria M.: 8 contracts May–Oct, all $10–150	Poor
8	**SaaS / 2D explainer video**	≈7 2D + 9 explainer per 51 h	Mixed; SaaS post at 50+	5/25	$100–500 per video	Iqra A.: 9 jobs Aug 13–Oct 16	Poor
9	**HubSpot / CRM fix & cleanup**	10 per ~66 h	3/10 under 15; 1/10 at 50+	3/25	$150–200 fixed; $10–30/hr	Lee M.: 11 contracts from Aug 12 (heavily padded)	Adjacent
10	**Mobile app fixes (Flutter / React Native)**	≈12/day (highest)	9/20 at 50+	3–4/25	$3–47/hr; $200–1,500	Michael B.: $1,325 (Sep 25); Nahom D.: ≈$8/hr hourly	Possible, crowded
11	**Faceless YouTube editing**	10 per ~27 h	Mostly 10–20	Low	$15–150 per video	Muhammad S.: 10 contracts Sep 29–Oct 23	Poor
12	**Podcast / audio incl. AI-voice polish**	10 per ~47 h	4/10 at 20–50	3/25	$14–75 per episode	Jhonville L.: $15 job closed Oct 20	Poor

#	Niche	Demand (title match)	Competition (proposal tiers)	No-badge in top 25	Budgets seen	Newest newcomer evidence (Observed)	Harry fit
13	**Unity game development**	≈4.4/day (≈⅓ art jobs)	**0/10 at 50+**; 5/10 under 10	4/25	$20–1,100; $15–50/hr	Andres R.: first contract Sep 6, 6 jobs by Oct 21	Possible (game background)
14	**AI-coding-agent evaluation**	Several posts per week	50+ on most	Nigerian profiles nearly absent	$10–30/hr; $100–150/hr (country-locked)	No Nigerian evaluator with history found	**Side bids**
15	**Nigerian-language translation / MTPE**	1–3 per week	10–15 Hausa; 20–50+ Igbo/Pidgin	Mostly badged	$15–1,500	Onyebuchi E.: $1,094 app test from Oct 6	Only if fluent
16	**AI image generation (e-commerce)**	≈2 genuine/day	5/10 at 20–50	6/25	$25 test; $7–35/hr; $750–864	Dilara S.: $25 → $750; new job Oct 15	Poor
17	**Telegram bots**	≈1 dev post/day	15–50	1/25	$55–800	Melek J.: $800 bot (Jul 30)	Skill keyword
18	**Klaviyo / email automation**	10 per ~76 h	**0/10 at 50+**	**1/25**	$10–20 setup; $8–35/hr	NHI N.: entered via $11K agency-style hourly	Only bundled with n8n
19	**Amazon listing / Seller Central**	High but noisy	Mixed	**0/25** (23/25 Pakistan)	$10–150; ≈$7/hr	Manazir H.: Top Rated in ~3 months at $6.99/hr	Poor
20	**English transcription / caption QA**	Daily	Crowded	Mostly badged	$5–10/hr	Osaivbie I.: $10K QA contract at ≈$10/hr	Poor
21	**YouTube stickman animation**	4 reposts of one job on Oct 25	Under 5	5/25 (2D)	$30 per 15-min video	Ahmad Z.: ≈$6.40/hr	Poor
22	**YouTube automation scripts**	10 per ~17 h (templated)	5–15; 10/10 expert	**1/25** (8 Nigerians, all badged)	$25 script; $35–75/hr posts	Femi C. (NG, Top Rated): contract Oct 13	Poor
23	**Motion graphics (After Effects)**	10 per ~31 h	5/10 at 20–50	2/25	$15–1,250	No pure no-badge case found	Poor

#	Niche	Demand (title match)	Competition (proposal tiers)	No-badge in top 25	Budgets seen	Newest newcomer evidence (Observed)	Harry fit
24	**Canva social graphics (standalone)**	10 per ~29 h	4/10 at 20–50	**0/25**	$5–250	None found	Poor
25	**Chrome extensions**	≈0.4/day	3/10 at 50+	1/25	$900–10,000; $5–50 tester gigs	Dika B.: $50 → hourly at ≈$5–7/hr	Skill keyword
26	**Figma UI/UX**	10 per ~52 h	7/10 at 20+	**0/25**	$5–50/hr; $2,000	No solo newcomer found	Poor
27	**Generic "AI trainer" / RLHF**	1 "RLHF" post in index	50+	Crowded Nigerian profiles, little history	Rate not given	Ojiaku V.: AI-trainer title, only GHL/VA contracts	Poor
28	**Discord bots**	≈0.4/day; **0 in 72 h**	3/4 at 20–50	3/25	$100–1,500	Raed O.: $100 bot (Apr)	Skill keyword
—	**MCP / Claude connector builds**	1–2 posts seen	50+	n/a	$60–120/hr (OneNote→Notion+Claude)	None	**Keyword inside core**
—	**Payments (Stripe + Paystack/Flutterwave) & WhatsApp API**	No Upwork counts	n/a	n/a	$35–50 catalog gigs; ≈$14–20/hr (India)	Listings only	Skill keyword (Nigerian edge)
—	**QA / app testing**	Upwork "QA testers rose" headline (Nov 2025)	n/a	n/a	$5–50 tester gigs	Michael B.'s $5 tester job (Oct 22)	Review-seeding only
—	**AI governance / compliance docs**	LinkedIn postings +150% YoY	n/a	n/a	$800–2,000/day (vendor)	None	Later stage

Developer niches: security reviews pay, scraping wins, bots are too thin

Supabase security work is the highest-value new finding. Observed: Supabase-titled posts ran at about 3.3 a day, and 7 of the 10 newest were expert level. Several were plain security engagements: "Independent Security & Architecture Review – Deno / Supabase AI Application" at **$530** with 15–20 proposals (job), and "Senior PostgreSQL / Supabase Security Engineer" to validate RLS on a patch, at **$300** (job). A Firebase post read "Most of it was built with Claude Code" ($300, 50+) (job). Another job wanted an **"MCP Server Developer to Connect Claude to Our Supabase and Notion Data"** (50+ proposals; client rated 5.0 over 41 reviews) (job).

Search was almost fully badged (0 of 25 for "Supabase Firebase developer"), yet the clearest no-badge success of the whole pull is here. **Younes M.** (Morocco, $45/hr, ex-Oracle) has 7 fixed jobs worth $10K+ since June 2026. They include a $1,860 PR review ("he doesn't just implement something because I've asked for it — he thinks about the wider impact, flags potential issues"), a **$1,500 "Personal Trainer App security**

review" on Oct 15 and a $175 weekly Supabase architecture review on Oct 20. His overview opens: "I take SaaS apps that were built fast with Lovable, Cursor, Bolt or a rushed MVP and make them safe to launch" (profile). **Michael B.** (Germany, $40/hr, no badge) sells "I test with two normal accounts, prove every gap, fix it and re-test". He shows **two sample RLS reviews** as portfolio items and won a "Software Auditor of SaaS Platform" contract on Oct 23 (profile).

Inference: sample audit write-ups substitute for reviews here. Younes's corporate background probably helped, and how much of his success transfers to a junior seller is unknown.

Web scraping is the most winnable developer niche, and the cheapest. Observed: 20 posts arrived in about 4.25 days. Only 2 had 50+ proposals, and many were $50–150 fixed. Examples are "Web Scraping for Price Data" across 8–10 sites for $52 (job) and a $130 lead scrape (job). The better-paid posts asked for pipelines or prior platform experience: "Python Data Scraping Web+PDF from Public Filings" at **$20–100/hr** with 15–20 proposals (job), and an **$2,500** ad-spy platform for an "Engineer Who Has Scraped This Before" with 10–15 proposals (job). Sellers are in a price race: 20 of the top 25 charge ≤$10/hr (search). **Shoukat A.** (Pakistan, $3.33/hr, no badge) earns $10–225 per job and started two new hourly scraping contracts on Oct 21–22. His overview opens with a problem ("Majority of web scraping projects fail because anti-bot systems...") and his portfolio has 12 named-site scrapers (profile). **Raed O.** started on $35 scraping jobs in November 2025 and moved into bots and backends (profile).

Inference: for a developer, scraping is a review builder. Its profit lies in PDF/ETL and anti-bot pipelines, not in lead lists.

Mobile fixes have volume but heavy bidding. Unity has light bidding but needs shipped games. Observed: Flutter and React Native together produced about 12 posts a day, but **9 of the 20 newest had 50+ proposals** (Flutter search). Newcomers entered either cheaply (Nahom D. at ≈$8/hr on a $250 job that turned hourly (profile)) or with a narrow, provable offer (Michael B.'s $1,325 widget job). The one Nigerian in the top 25, **Olajire A.** (Top Rated Plus, $80K+), leads with his own voice-AI banking product in Pidgin, Yoruba, Igbo and Hausa and with "rescue stalled codebases" (profile).

Unity had **no post at 50+** among the 10 newest, and 5 had fewer than 10 proposals (search). About a third of those posts are art jobs, though. **Andres R.** (Peru, no badge) won his first contract on Sep 6 and got rehired by the same client. He was on 6 jobs by Oct 21, ranking on playable builds and Google Play titles. Review: "If you can imagine a game mechanic or feature, he can build it" (profile).

Bots and extensions are skill keywords, not niches. Observed: "Discord bot" returned **4 jobs in 10 days and none in the last 72 hours** (search). Telegram development ran at about 1 post a day, mostly crypto sniper, copy-trade and payment bots ($55–600) (job). Chrome extensions ran at about 0.4 a day and the top 25 was dominated by $500K+ specialists (search). The newcomer path seen there paid **≈$5–7/hr**: Dika B. turned a $50 extension job into 1,534 hours at $4.95/hr (profile). The one no-badge bot seller earning well, **Melek J.** ($30/hr, $10K+), wins on trading-domain knowledge, not on Discord or Telegram skill (profile).

Business tools: Notion/ClickUp opens for Nigerians, Etsy and TikTok Shop are soft but cheap

Observed: Notion, Airtable and ClickUp together produced only about 12 posts per 72 hours, and most drew 20–50 proposals. The talent side, however, is unusually open: in the "Notion Airtable ClickUp setup" search, **3 of 25 had no badge and 9 of 25 were in Nigeria**. Example posts:

- "Notion Database Expert Needed" at $12–35/hr (job)
- "AI Consultant: Migrate OneNote to Notion, Set Up Claude Integration" at **$60–120/hr**, from a client with $333K spent (job)
- "Fix our Airtable to Make to Shopify connection" at $20–40/hr (job)

- a $150 "ClickUp AI Super Agent Creation" (job)

Philips E. (Lagos, BSc CS 2024, $10/hr, no badge) shows the ladder. His first job was a $15 Notion workspace (Aug 4–6; "Top-tier work!... Will definitely be working with him again"). Then came a $231.67 SOP migration, a **$650 "Jarvis Notion System Build"** and an apparent follow-on from the same client, "Jarvis Core system, installable app, GA4\Stripe", started **Oct 7** (profile). **Miriam A.** (Abuja, no badge) earns ≈$15/hr on two long ClickUp admin contracts. One review reads "detail-oriented, solution-focused... would gladly hire her again" (profile).

Inference: Notion/ClickUp pays like "VA plus" (≈$15/hr) unless it is tied to automation or AI. The Airtable and Notion-plus-Claude posts are exactly where an automation developer has an edge.

HubSpot rewards "fix my existing portal" work. Observed: budgets included $150 for a HubSpot–Stripe integration (job), a $150 French HubSpot + Meta CAPI setup with 5–10 proposals (job) and a $1,200 HubSpot + deliverability setup (job). The newcomer seen winning, Lee M., is a padding case and is covered in the section on profile patterns below.

Klaviyo posts are soft, but sellers are fully badged. Observed: no Klaviyo post reached 50+ proposals, but 24 of 25 sellers in search had badges, and their titles lead with revenue claims ("30M+ in Client Revenue"). Klaviyo posts increasingly ask for automation too. An Australian client with **$108,681 spent** posted "Ecommerce Automation N8N Shopify Zoho Klaviyo Claude" (10–15 proposals) and an ops-automation role with **fewer than 5** proposals (job; job).

E-commerce marketplace work is easy to win and pays little. Etsy and TikTok Shop were the softest posts in the whole pull: **0 of 20 at 20+ proposals**. A UK client with **$151,966 spent** wanted help getting approved on TikTok Shop for $50 with 5–10 proposals (job). Javeria M.'s eight 2026 TikTok Shop contracts total under about $300 (profile). **Precious O.** (Lagos) went from a $5 crochet-PDF job to $800 and $350 Etsy projects, ≈$15/hr hourly work and a Shopify build on Oct 19. She opens with "Open Etsy. Search for your best-selling product. Can you find your own listing?" (profile).

Amazon (0 of 25 unbadged, 23 of 25 in Pakistan, ≈$7/hr), Canva (0 of 25 unbadged) and Figma (0 of 25 unbadged, agency-scale profiles with 267 portfolio items) are the hardest to enter from zero.

Language and AI data: the clearest Nigerian edge, at modest rates

Observed: this is the one area where Nigerian nationality is the qualification. A US client (**$3.35M spent, 4.96★ over 1,431 reviews**) posted "Native Speakers of Yoruba Needed: High-Fidelity Voice Data for AI Training" on Oct 23. It pays **$605** in milestones: a $5 test, $300 for 1.5 hours of scripted reading and 3 × $100 dialogue sessions. It had **10–15 proposals, no JSS/hours/earnings minimum and a cost of 17 Connects**. It requires a USB condenser or XLR mic and wired headphones (job). The Igbo version drew 20–50 proposals (job). The client was running parallel posts for Twi, Wolof, Zulu and other languages.

Other live posts:

- A Chinese buyer (4.94★) pays **$0.50 per audio minute** for Igbo transcription. It hired on Oct 19, 20, 22 and 24, and the post costs **8 Connects** (job).
- Talent Store's "Hausa Audio Naturalness Evaluation" caps pay at **$4–5/hr** but has hired 28 people (job).
- A Hausa phoneme annotator role pays **$40/hr** (job).
- A German client with $1.07M spent posted a **$1,500** English→Hausa app translation with 10–15 proposals (job).
- "Pidgin Transcription and Translation" drew 50+ proposals and 23 interviews for one hire (job). Pidgin is not scarce.

Hamza M. (Kaduna, $20/hr) shows how to rank. His title is "Native Hausa Translator & Localizer | AI Data Trainer", his bio has numbers ("3,325+ audio files") and his portfolio holds STT/TTS error-analysis case studies. $11,710 of his earnings came from one hourly client (profile). **Mercy E.** gets around NDAs by publishing labelled self-made Yoruba RLHF and MT-evaluation samples (profile). Even a mostly-design profile, Pelumi O. (no badge), landed a **$2,828** Talent Store transcription contract (profile).

Off Upwork, funded dataset projects are real: Masakhane is building 50-language datasets (Dawan Africa). Pay is modest, though: RWS TrainAI lists Yoruba at **$8** (Lever). Eligibility is contested. One source says Outlier dropped Nigeria in July 2026 while another lists it as open, and Mindrift, Micro1, CrowdGen and Mercor are reported open (Raenest; BRYME). WhatsApp "agents" charging sign-up fees are scams (BRYME).

AI-coding-agent evaluation is the developer version of this work. Observed: "Senior Software Engineer – AI Coding Agent Evaluation & Task Development" pays **$20–30/hr** for 5 hires. It requires "hands-on experience with AI coding agents (Claude Code, Codex, or similar)", has no preferred-qualification minimums and costs 23 Connects. It had 50+ proposals (job). The $100–150/hr version is limited to US, Canada and Western Europe (job). A Nigeria-filtered search found **no Nigerian freelancer with a code-evaluation track record**. The closest, Akintunde T., claims "Code Review, RLHF" with 0 contracts and no samples (profile). Generic "AI trainer/RLHF" is the opposite case: one post in the index (50+ proposals) and a crowd of Nigerian profiles with titles but no Upwork AI history.

Media and 3D: one coder's side door, the rest are craft businesses at $6–10/hr

Observed: Blender posts drew the fewest bids of the media niches. "Blender Artist Needed: Sunglasses Try-On Models" at $200 had **fewer than 5 proposals** (job), a UK client posted a $3,000 Unreal weapon rig (job), and a client with $78.6K spent wanted metal materials (job). **YING KIT C.** (no badge, $45/hr, 43 jobs) is the coder's model. His title is "Blender & Python Automation | 3D Rendering, ComfyUI & RunPod". He gets repeat $80 environment jobs (a new one started Oct 25) and a $450 "Automated Product Image Creation" job. His portfolio case studies carry measured claims, and one item notes "Built with Claude Code. 3,699 lines, one file, one command" (profile).

The other media niches convert to low hourly pay:

- Faceless YouTube editing at $80–150 per video (Muhammad S.'s 10 contracts in four weeks)
- stickman animation at **$30 per 15-minute video** (job)
- podcast edits at $14–65 (Jhonville L.)
- AI image work, where a client with $106K spent pays **$7–10/hr** (job)

The better-paid exceptions sell to businesses with products: Iqra A.'s $100–500 SaaS explainers (profile) and Dilara S.'s $25 test that became a $750 AI apparel catalogue (profile). YouTube scriptwriting is a Nigerian stronghold (8 of the top 25), but all 8 are Top Rated.

Combined top 10 across both studies

This table merges the October 24 leaders with the new niches, ranked for a **generic no-badge, zero-job seller** on winnability first and pay second. **Inference**, built on the Observed columns of both pulls. Virtual assistance (Oct 24 #6) drops out because Notion/ClickUp systems work is "VA plus" at ≈$15/hr against ≈$5–7/hr. Two niches are merged: vibe-coded app rescue (#9) and Supabase security review are the same buyers.

#	Niche	Study	Why it ranks (Observed)	Typical early pay	Harry fit
1	AI UGC video ads	Oct 24 #1	2/20 posts at 50+; ≥9/25 unbadged; Boluwatife D. new contract Oct 22	$10–20 test ads → $2,880 hourly	Poor (wastes coding edge)
2	Appointment / DM setting	Oct 24 #2	13/20 posts under 5 proposals; Charity F. (NG) 5 contracts to Oct 20	≈$5–10/hr	Poor
3	**n8n / Make / AI automation fixes**	Oct 24 #3	10/20 at 50+, but $50–220 newcomer fixes in Oct; #1 search result had $60 earned	$50–220 → $35/hr	**Core**
4	Short-form video editing	Oct 24 #4	Highest velocity; Dua D. ~20 contracts in 7 weeks	$10–30 per edit	Poor
5	Shopify fixes / tracking	Oct 24 #5	7/20 under 10 proposals; Varnika C. 13 jobs in Oct	$50–230 → $880	Adjacent
6	**AI-built app rescue + Supabase security review**	Oct 24 #9 + new	$300–1,500 review posts; Younes M. $1,500 (Oct 15); Akram S. $400 audit	$300–1,500 fixed	**Core, upgraded**
7	**Notion / Airtable / ClickUp systems**	New #1	9/25 Nigerian in search; Philips E. $15 → $650 → repeat (Oct 7)	≈$15/hr; $650 builds	Adjacent (Airtable/Claude)
8	**Google Sheets / Apps Script & scripts**	Oct 24 #7–8	Rayan S. $55/hr from first contract; Python search ~7/25 unbadged	$100–850; $55–60/hr	**Core side door**
9	**Web scraping / data pipelines**	New #3	≈4.7/day, only 2/20 at 50+; Shoukat A. new contracts Oct 21–22	$50–150 (≈$3–10/hr) → $20–100/hr pipelines	**Core side door**
10	Etsy SEO + Canva digital products	New #4	0/10 posts at 20+; Precious O. (NG) $5 → $800 → Shopify build	≈$15/hr	Poor

Inference: for a *Nigerian* newcomer, Yoruba/Igbo/Hausa AI voice data would enter this list around #8. It has a $605 job with 10–15 proposals and no minimums from a 744-job client, but its ceiling is lower and it depends on language and equipment. Across both studies the top 10 splits cleanly into taste-and-hustle niches (#1, 2, 4, 10) and proof-gated technical niches (#3, 5, 6, 8, 9). Only the second group pays Harry for what he can already do.

Why winners rank and get hired, and the padding not to copy

Observed traits of new winners in this pull match October 24 and add some detail.

Narrow, buyer-type titles. Examples: "Notion Consultant | Notion Workspace | Notion Expert | Notion AI", "SaaS Explainer Video Expert", "Blender & Python Automation", "Native Hausa Translator & Localizer | AI Data Trainer".

An opening line about the client's problem. Examples: Younes's "built fast with Lovable... make them safe to launch", Shoukat's anti-bot sentence, Precious's "Can you find your own listing?".

Proof the buyer can check. This means sample RLS audits with before/after tests (Michael B.), named-site scrapers (Shoukat), Play Store builds (Andres R.), Chrome Web Store screenshots (Sumit S. ranked #9 for extensions with zero extension contracts on Upwork (profile)), self-made, labelled demo evaluations (Mercy E.) and measured engineering case studies (YING KIT C.).

A cheap first step. Examples: $20–30 consultations (Philips, Younes), paid tests (Dilara's $25) and "approve a representative sample before expanding the set" (YING KIT C.).

Repeat clients. Andres R. was rehired the day after his first contract closed. YING KIT C. has five $80 biome jobs from one client. The Igbo transcription buyer hired four times in six days. Philips's Jarvis client came back.

Badges arrive fast. Manazir H. reached Top Rated in about three months, Malik S. on a 2026 account, and Raed O. is Top Rated with only $1K+ earned. So "no badge" is a short phase, and the first five clean reviews matter more.

Inference: many of the low-proposal posts were minutes or hours old, so speed still governs whether a 0-review proposal is read.

Patterns not to copy (Observed on profiles; the risk is Inference). Several winning profiles also carry padding that careful clients or Upwork's trust team can spot.

Lee M. (HubSpot) shows nine long, similarly phrased 5★ reviews in about nine weeks on a mid-2026 account. He also lists **about 70 employment entries named only by industry** ("SaaS Company", "Legal Services") and 46 portfolio images that look AI-generated, with mock 2025 dates (profile).

Iqra A. claims "6+ years... 500+ completed SaaS explainer videos" on an account whose contracts start in August 2026. She lists ~50 generic studio employers and ~12 "education" keyword strings, and two portfolio thumbnails carry a **"BY ARIF" watermark**.

Employment and testimonial padding. Philips E. lists 13 employers with generic agency names. Precious O. lists job-post titles and "JM Family Enterprises" as employers. Miriam A. quotes a Pipedrive testimonial that does not appear in her Upwork history.

Keyword and hashtag dumps. Muhammad S. uses bold Unicode and about 200 keyword phrases. Ayusha H. lists 26 tools plus hashtags. Javeria M. ends her overview with about 20 hashtags and sets a US Pacific timezone while based in Pakistan. Dmytro Z. has 267 keyword-stuffed portfolio items.

Portfolio work that may not be the seller's. Adam A.'s portfolio includes the note "Kindly ignore just a kywords below" and credits renders to the Substance asset library and another artist (profile).

Titles without matching history. Ojiaku V. is titled "AI Data Trainer", but every visible contract is GoHighLevel, web design or VA work (profile). Akintunde T. claims "Code Review, RLHF" with no samples. Jhonville L. lists Audible as an employer, unverified.

Same-day micro-gigs that look like review seeding. Michael B. has a $5 tester job opened and closed on Oct 22 with a 5★ review. Dika B. has a $12 static-site job with a long review.

Client-side red flags.

- A $96-spent Nigerian account reposted a US client's Everfit brief at $500 and posted a $5 Revit job (job).
- A voiceover client has 83 posts and $135 spent (job).
- A Unity client rated 3.78 asked for AppLovin account access (job).
- An Amazon "client" post reads like a freelancer's service listing (job).
- Crypto sniper and copy-trade bot posts carry dispute and compliance risk.

Harry: keep automation, add security reviews and data pipelines

The October 24 recommendation stands, and the new data strengthens it (Inference). Upwork has had no Specialized Profiles since May 28, 2026 (Upwork Help), so Harry needs one coherent story. The new niches sort into four groups.

Strengthens the core: Supabase/Firebase security reviews. This turns the vague "vibe-coded app rescue" into a priced, deliverable entry product ($300–1,500, Younes M.). It can be won without reviews by showing sample audits (Michael B.). It also matches posts that name Claude Code directly (job).

Adds a side door: web scraping as data pipelines. Scraping into n8n, Google Sheets or Supabase gives a steady flow (≈4.7 posts/day) of $50–150 review-builders with fewer 50+ posts than n8n (2 of 20 against 10 of 20). Its upper tier, "Web+PDF from Public Filings" at $20–100/hr, rewards exactly the API and pipeline skills Harry has.

Fold in as skills and keywords, not titles.

- MCP/Claude connector builds (the "Connect Claude to Our Supabase and Notion Data" post)
- Airtable/Notion + Make/n8n fixes
- Klaviyo/Shopify ops automation (the $108K-spent client's n8n + Claude posts)
- Stripe + Paystack/Flutterwave and WhatsApp Business API, a Nigerian edge where Upwork catalog gigs sell at only $35–50 (Upwork catalog)
- Telegram/Discord bots

Side income, not positioning. Two niches fit here:

- **AI-coding-agent evaluation** ($20–30/hr). It requires Claude Code experience, which he has, and no Nigerian evaluator showed up in search. It costs 23 Connects into a 50+ field, so one or two bids at most.
- **Nigerian-language voice data and transcription**, if he is a native Yoruba, Igbo or Hausa speaker. The $605 job needs a decent mic and gives an early 5★ review, the way Simon K.'s language eval did on October 24. Off-Upwork platforms (Mindrift, Micro1, CrowdGen, Mercor) are worth checking against their official country lists, and he should never pay a fee to join.

Do not add. Notion/ClickUp as a headline pays ≈$15/hr and is crowded with Nigerian peers. Blender/ComfyUI pipelines (YING KIT C.'s model) need 3D craft Harry has not shown. Roblox/Luau stays out of the profile for the reasons given on October 24; Unity's low bid counts are a reminder that game work is winnable, but only with shipped builds. Mobile app fixes are crowded at 9 of 20 posts with 50+ proposals.

Updated title (Inference): "AI Automation & Integration Developer — n8n, Claude Code, APIs & Supabase | Fix, Secure & Finish AI-Built Workflows and Apps." The opening line should name the pain: "Your workflow, scraper or AI-built app is 80% done and breaking or leaking data — I fix, secure and extend it, starting read-only."

Concise entry plan.

Days 1–7: build proof. Keep the five October 24 Loom portfolio items (n8n inbox triage, Vapi → Sheets log, webhook/API validation, Lovable + Supabase rescue, Apps Script tool), and replace or add two:

1. **A sample Supabase RLS security review.** Use a deliberately flawed demo app, test it with two normal accounts, write a risk-ranked fix list, and show the before/after policy tests. This copies Michael B.'s format.
2. **A scraper → n8n → Google Sheets/Supabase pipeline.** Handle pagination and one PDF source, add retry and error alerts, and include a Loom walkthrough.

An optional third item is a small MCP server that connects Claude to a Supabase table, mirroring the live post.

Set a public rate of ≈$20/hr and add a $20–30 consultation or "read-only audit call". Keep the profile honest: no invented employers and no claimed years he cannot show.

Days 3–30: spend about 80 Connects (≈6–8 proposals) in this order.

1. n8n/API fixes and Supabase/RLS or app-rescue posts under about 60 minutes old, payment-verified, scoped to one fix.
2. Scraping or data-pipeline posts at $100+ that mention PDFs, APIs or "Python".
3. At most one AI-coding-eval bid.
4. If he is a native speaker, one Nigerian-language voice-data or transcription post. These cost 8–17 Connects and come from repeat buyers.

Quote a fixed price, attach the matching Loom, and offer a 1–3 day turnaround. Turn every fix into a next step ("RLS fixed — want a monthly security re-check?"), because repeat clients drove almost every ladder observed. Keep the October 24 fallback trigger: if about 30 targeted proposals produce no interview, revisit the positioning.

Conclusion

The second pull changes the *shape* of the advice more than its direction. On October 24, "app rescue" was a promising but vague niche. On October 25 it had a concrete, priced product, the security/RLS review, which no-badge sellers were winning on the strength of sample write-ups rather than reviews. Scraping adds a high-volume, low-competition way to earn reviews inside the same automation story. Both leave Harry with one coherent profile in which every new skill points at the same buyer: someone with a half-built system that is broken, leaking or slow.

The broader lesson is that Nigerian advantage on Upwork shows up in two very different places. One is native-language AI data, where the nationality itself is the qualification and the pay is modest. The other is technical work buyers can verify, where Nigerians already rank (Olajire A., Philips E., Hamza M.) but only behind checkable proof. A newcomer who claims "AI Trainer" or "RLHF" without that proof joins the most crowded and least-hired group in the data. That is the clearest sign that proof assets, not keywords, decide who gets hired.